Hives (Urticaria)

Itchy raised welts and the signs of a severe allergic reaction

ABOUT THIS TOPIC

Hives are raised, itchy welts that can appear suddenly and change shape or location. They can have many triggers, and sometimes no clear cause is found. A pharmacist or clinician can advise on suitable treatment.

Everyday care and treatment

- Use cool compresses and avoid overheating or scratching where possible.
- Ask a pharmacist or clinician whether an antihistamine is suitable, particularly for children, pregnancy, breastfeeding, or other medicines.
- Avoid a suspected trigger if it is clear and safe to do so. Do not assume every episode is caused by food.
- Seek advice if hives persist, repeatedly return, worsen, or are accompanied by other symptoms.

WHEN TO GET HELP

Call local emergency services immediately for swelling of the tongue, mouth, or throat; trouble breathing or swallowing; faintness; or rapidly worsening symptoms. This may be a life-threatening allergic reaction.

Sources for further reading

NHS - Hives - https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/hives/

Reviewed for this educational handout: October 2026. Recommendations can change and depend on local guidance, age, pregnancy, other health conditions, and medicines. This handout is not a diagnosis or prescription.